

PUBLIC LIBRARIES

CITY OF MELTON

A COMMUNITY INFRASTRUCTURE RESEARCH REPORT

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(Image: Melton Library, Credit Mein T.)

ACKNOWLEDGMENT OF COUNTRY

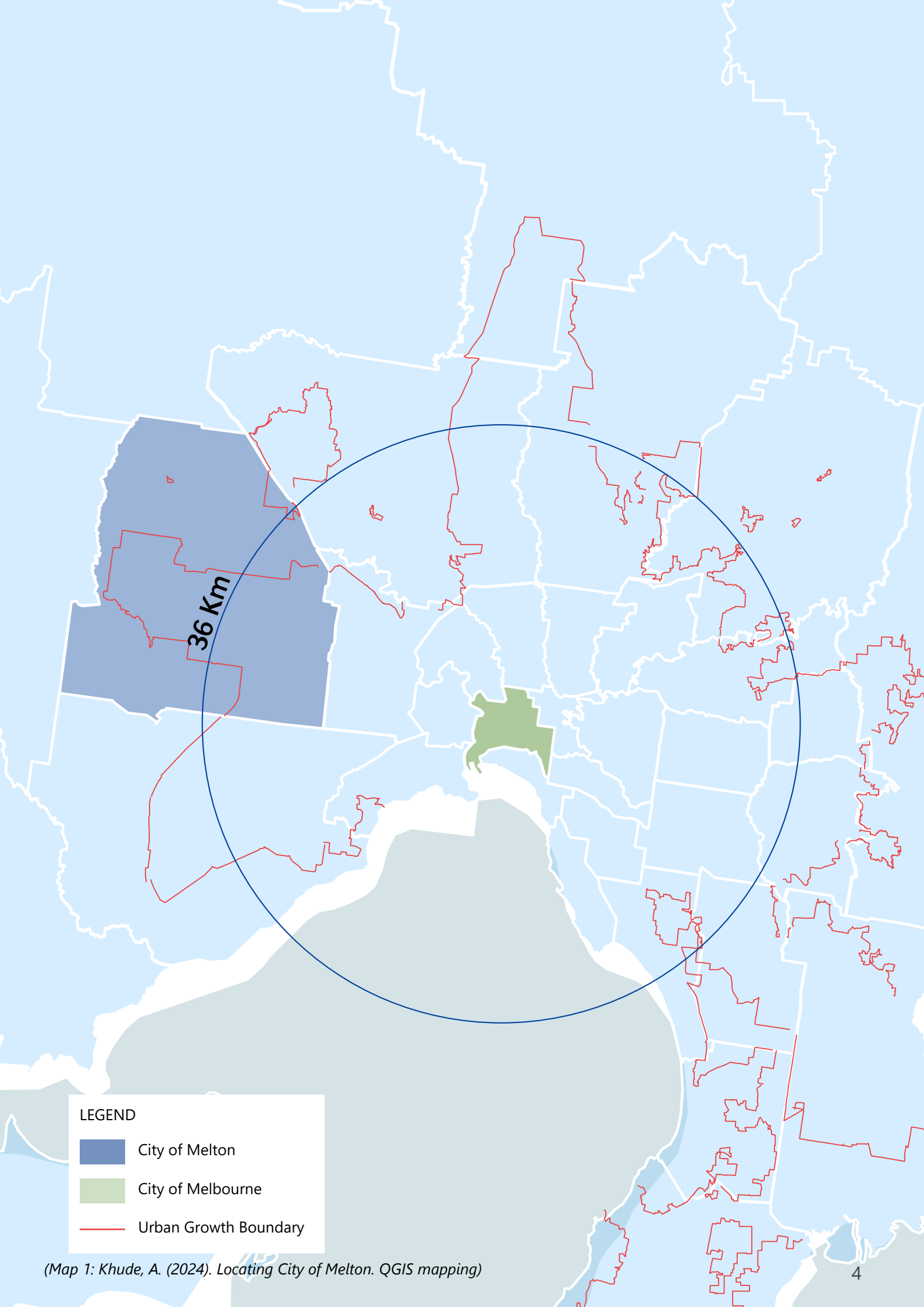
We acknowledge the traditional owners of the Woiwurrung, Boonwurrung and Wathaurong people of the Kulin Nation on whose unceded land we study and work on at Monash University and in Melton. We pay our respects to Elders both past, present and emerging and recognise and respect their continuous connection to this land, its waterways and community.



(Image: Dhumba Murmuk Djerring Artwork, Credit: Simone Thomson)

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LEGEND

-  City of Melton
-  City of Melbourne
-  Urban Growth Boundary

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 City of Melton

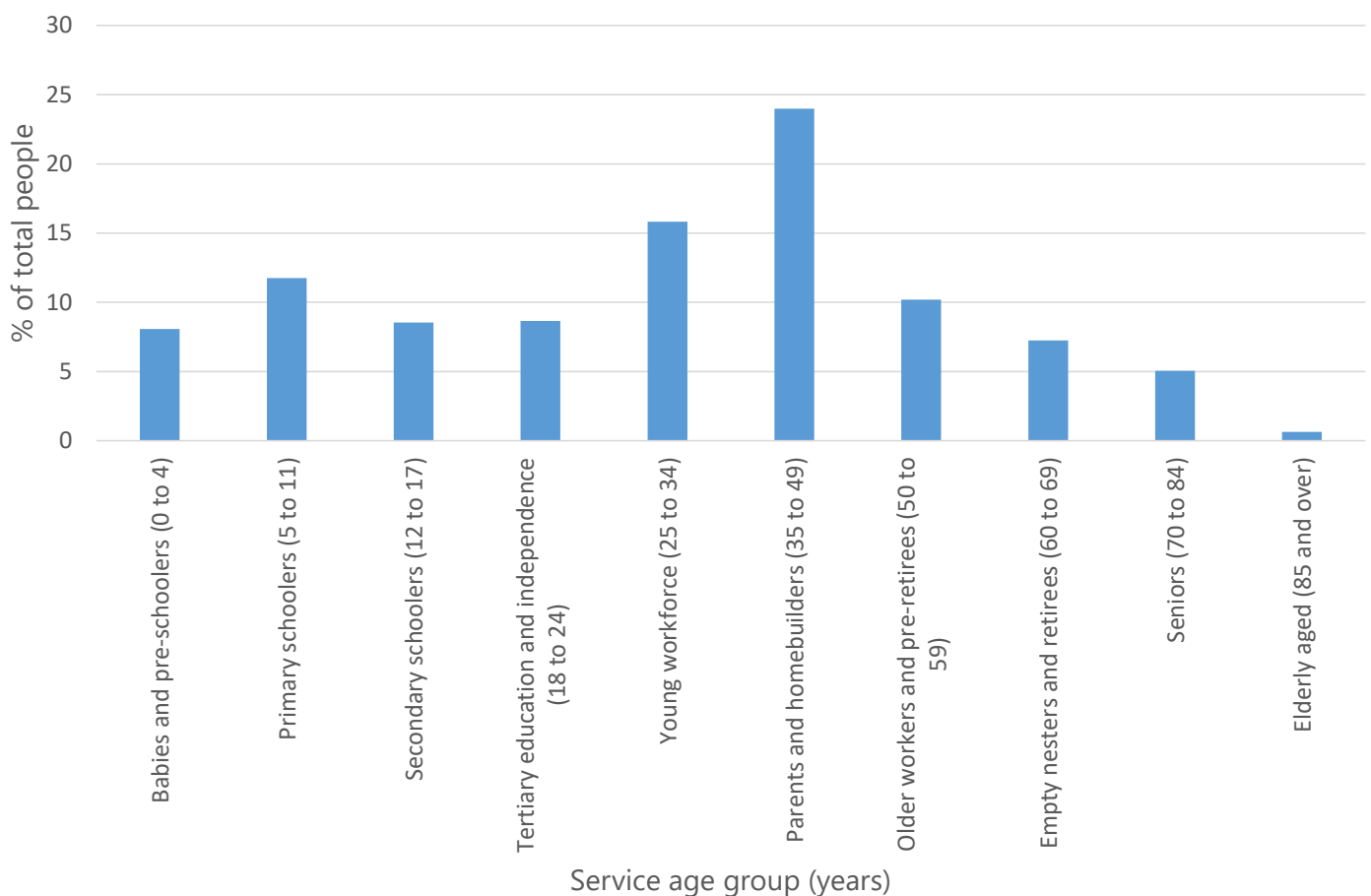
The City of Melton, located on Melbourne's western rural-urban fringe, is part of Victoria, Australia. Situated 36 kilometers west of Melbourne's central business district (CBD), Melton is a designated growth area experiencing rapid expansion due to its strategic location on the city's outskirts.

This community infrastructure research report has been commissioned by the City of Melton .

1.2 Age

According to the 2021 census, the total population of Melton LGA was 178,960 with 50.1% female and 49.9% male population.(ABS,2021)

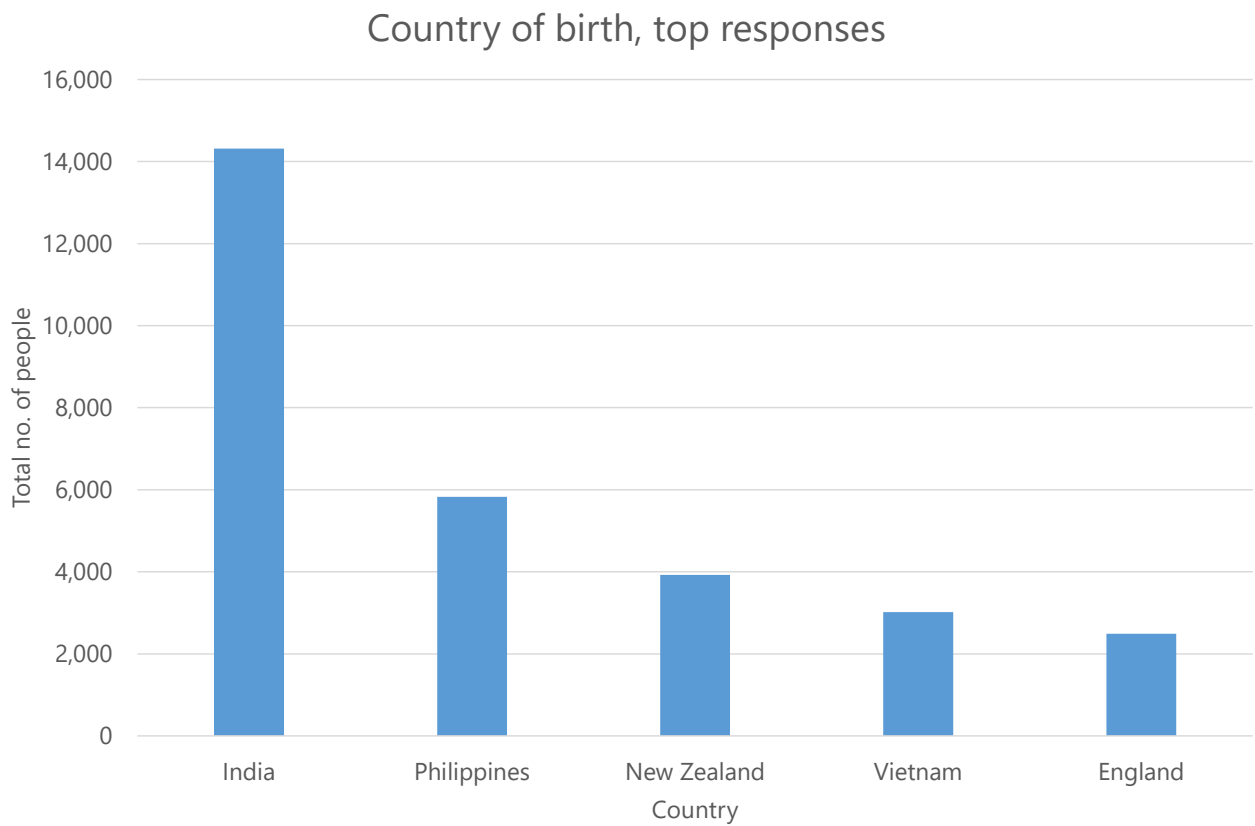
The median age in Melton is 33 years (ABS, 2021), with a population mainly made up of parents, home builders, a young workforce, and primary school-aged children.



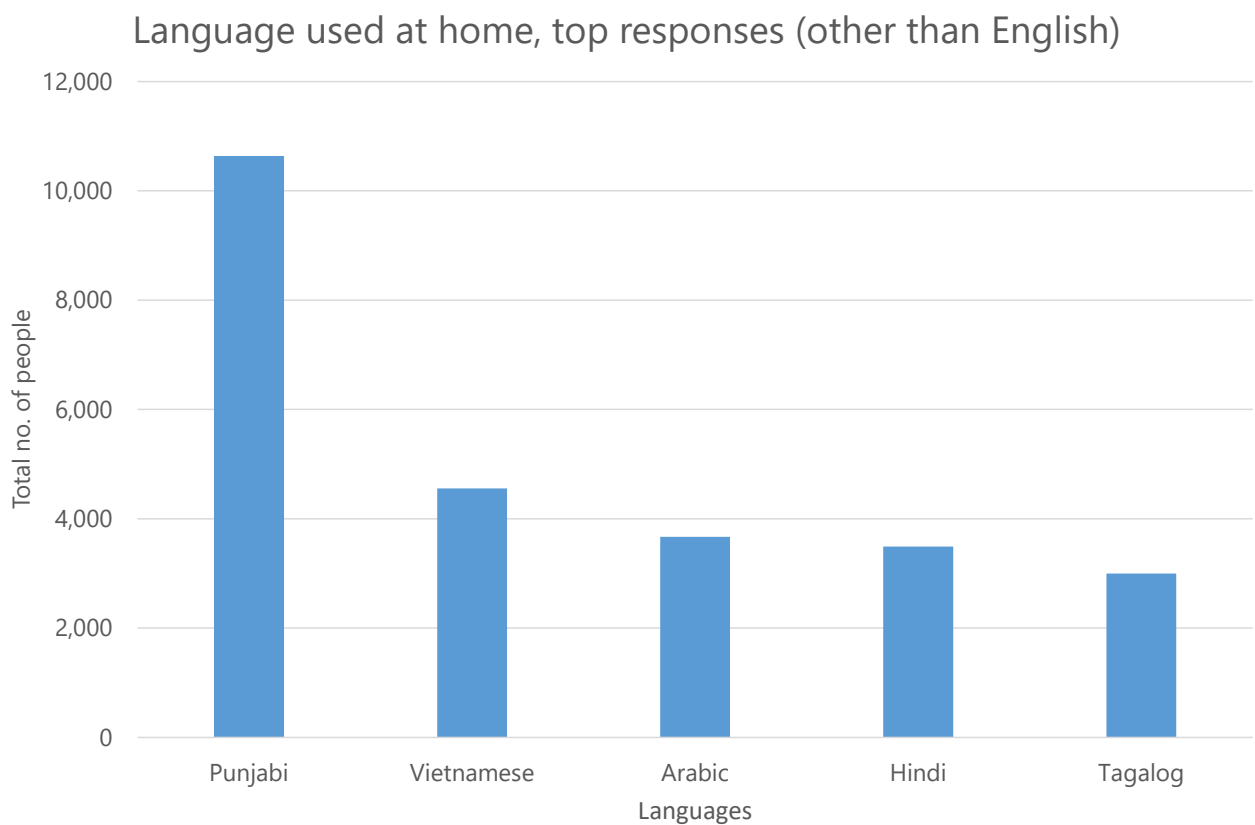
(Source: Australian Bureau of Statistics,Census 2021 (Usual residence data)., Presented by Khude A.)

1.3 Cultural Diversity

In 2021, 35.7% of the population in the City of Melton was born overseas, with migrants primarily coming from India, the Philippines, New Zealand, Vietnam, and England. The top languages spoken at home, aside from English, include Punjabi, Vietnamese, Arabic, Hindi, and Tagalog. This data highlights the cultural diversity present within the City of Melton.



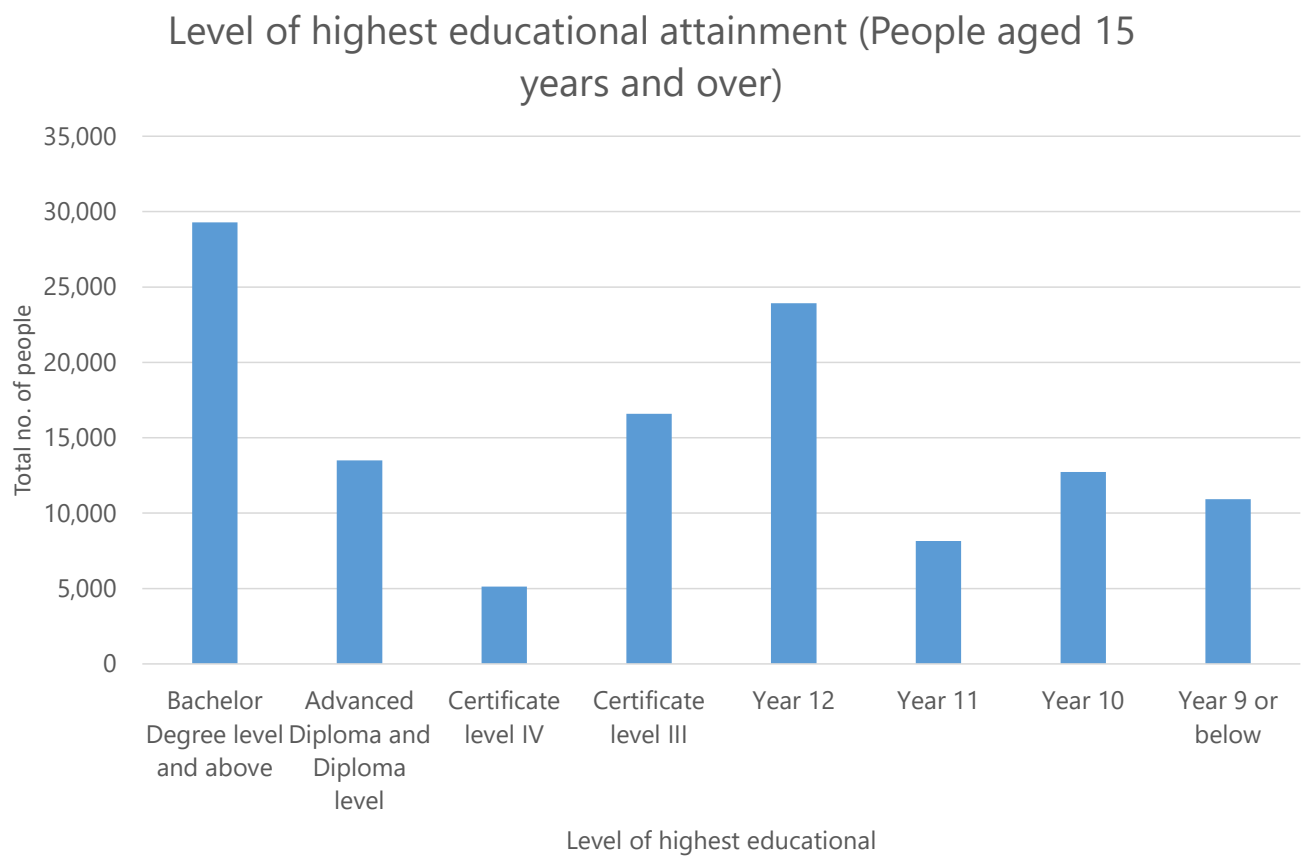
(Source: Australian Bureau of Statistics,Census 2021 (Usual residence data)., Presented by Khude A.)



(Source: Australian Bureau of Statistics,Census 2021 (Usual residence data)., Presented by Khude A.)

1.4 Education

As of 2021, 17.7% of individuals aged over 15 years in the City of Melton had completed Year 12 schooling (or its equivalent) while 21.6 % with a Bachelor degree and above.

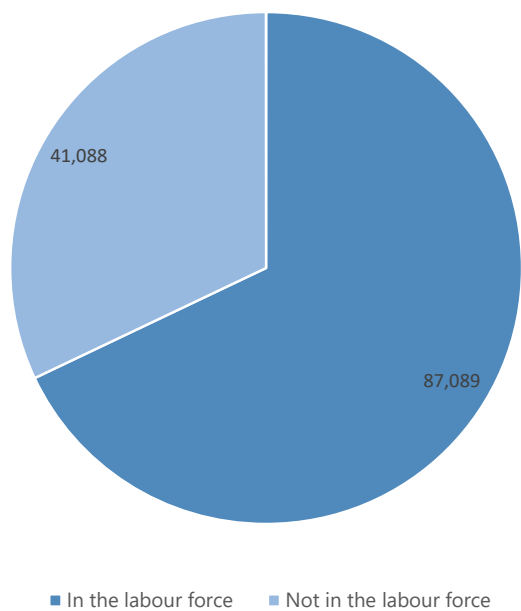


(Source: Australian Bureau of Statistics,Census 2021 (Usual residence data)., Presented by Khude A.)

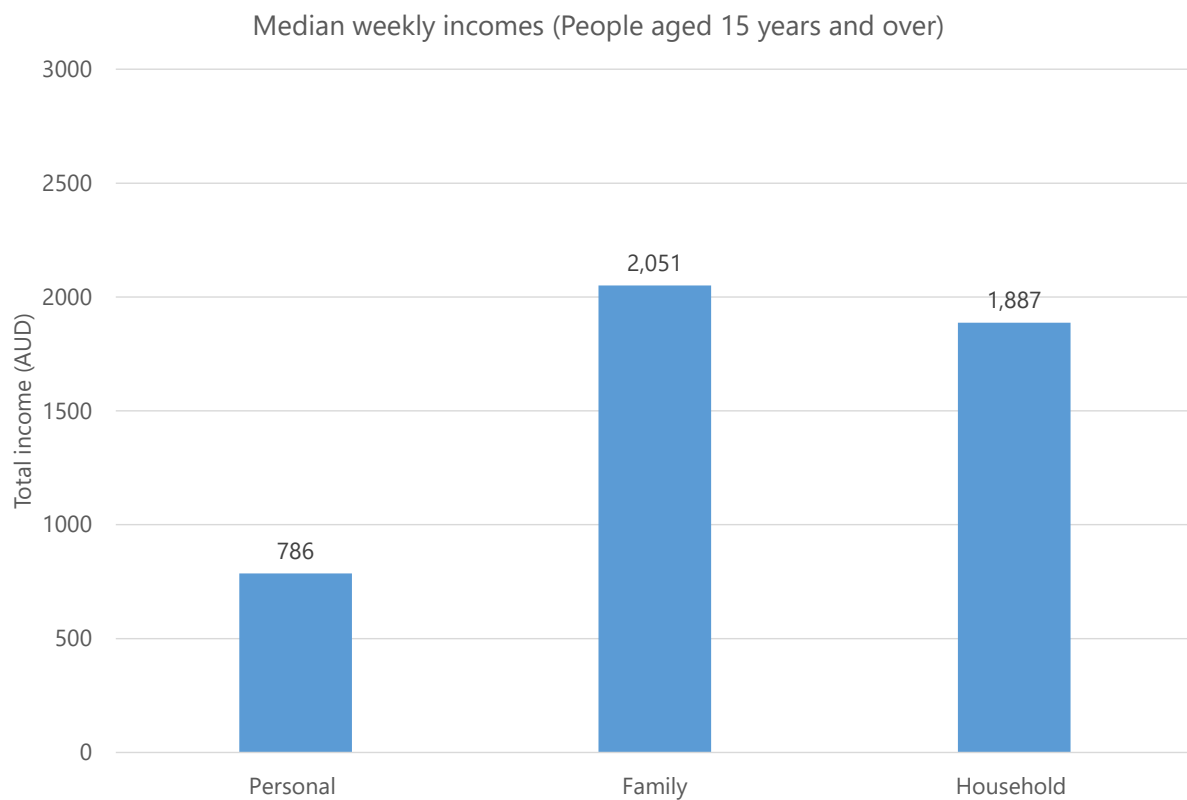
1.5 Work and Income

In 2021, a total of 81,444 people were employed in the City of Melton, with 61% of them working full-time and 31% working part-time.

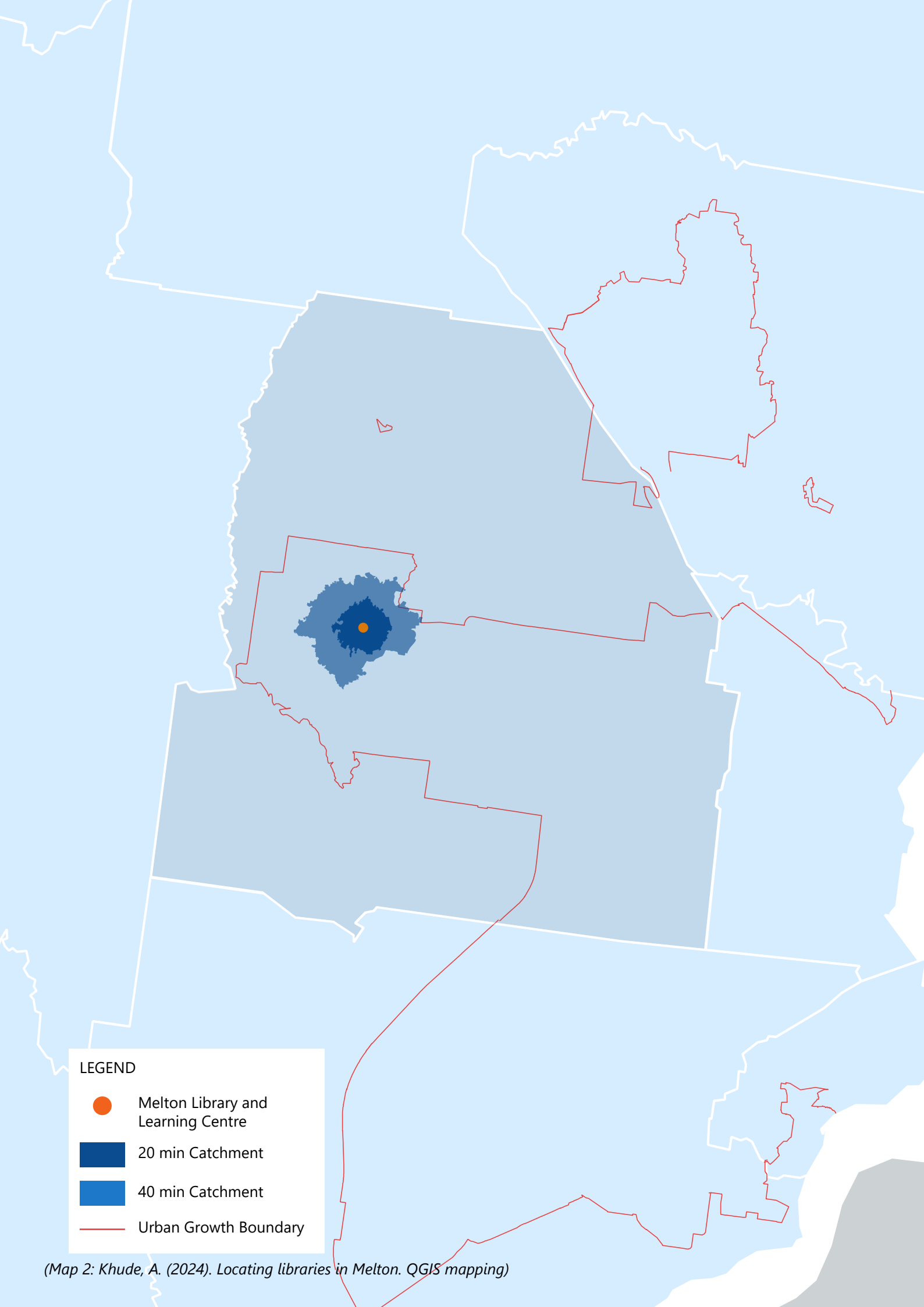
Participation in the labour force (People aged 15 years and over)



(Source: Australian Bureau of Statistics,Census 2021 (Usual residence data)., Presented by Khude A.)



(Source: Australian Bureau of Statistics, Census 2021 (Usual residence data), Presented by Khude A.)



LEGEND



Melton Library and
Learning Centre



20 min Catchment



40 min Catchment



Urban Growth Boundary

(Map 2: Khude, A. (2024). Locating libraries in Melton. QGIS mapping)

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Libraries as Community

Rehm, M. N., Eastern Kentucky University, Rehm, M. N., & Maples, J. (2023). *Libraries as Community: Investigating Social Infrastructure and Community Cohesion*. In *Kentucky Journal of Undergraduate Scholarship* (Vol. 6, Issue 1, p. Article 5) [Journal-article]. <https://encompass.eku.edu/kjus/vol6/iss1/5>

Public libraries play a crucial role in fostering community cohesion and strengthening social bonds. The research shows a positive, statistical significance between the strength of a library and community cohesion. The study suggests that individuals living in areas with well-regarded libraries tend to feel a stronger connection to their community, participate more actively in civic life, and enjoy a higher quality of life. The findings indicate that strong public library systems are linked to greater social cohesion and civic engagement. Libraries are highlighted as key social infrastructure that helps build relationships and address societal challenges. The research emphasizes the importance of public libraries in supporting democratic participation and enhancing community resilience.

2.2 Libraries building communities

Rosenfeldt, D. & State Library of Victoria. (2006). *Libraries building communities. Performance Measurement and Metrics*, 7–3, 185–192. <https://doi.org/10.1108/14678040610713147>

The Libraries Building Communities research have analysed a vital role and contributions of public libraries in Victoria, Australia. Findings indicate that Victorians highly value free library services, public Libraries significantly strengthen communities by providing access to information and technology, fostering lifelong learning and social networks. A high percentage of library users are retirees, students, and parents, challenging stereotypes of libraries serving only the elite. The study underscores the necessity for libraries to demonstrate their community impact, especially in light of shifting government funding and policies aimed at community resilience. There is a strong correlation between library usage and community engagement, with libraries serving as safe spaces for social interaction.

2.3 Public Libraries and Social Capital

Gong, H., Japzon, A. C., & Chen, C. (2008). *Public Libraries and Social Capital in Three New York City Neighbourhoods*. In *Royal Dutch Geographical Society KNAG, Tijdschrift Voor Economische En Sociale Geografie* (Vol. 99, Issue 1, pp. 65–83).

The study examines the impact of social capital on public library usage in three New York City neighbourhoods: the Upper West Side, the Hub, and Flushing. The Upper West Side, known for its strong social connections, has a well-used library that hosts numerous community events. In contrast, the Hub, a marginalized area, sees low library usage and minimal community engagement. Meanwhile, Flushing, a diverse immigrant neighbourhood, experiences high library attendance, catering to various languages and cultures. The analysis shows that social capital significantly influences library usage, with higher levels of social capital linked to increased engagement. The study also suggests that traditional measures of social capital may miss key collective benefits, highlighting the need to consider structural and spatial factors when assessing social capital's impact on library use.



(Image: Bird's eye view of the La Trobe Reading Room, State Library Victoria. Credit: Patrick Rodriguez)



(Image: Monash Public Library Service, n.d.)



(Image: Monash Public Library Service, n.d.)

2.4 Library as social infrastructure

Van Melik, R., & Merry, M. S. (2021). *Retooling the public library as social infrastructure: a Dutch illustration*. *Social & Cultural Geography*, 24(5), 758–777. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14649365.2021.1965195>

The paper highlights the transformation of a public library in a Dutch town into a vital social infrastructure that fosters community engagement and skill-sharing. The library hosts a variety of activities including lunch meetings, knitting clubs, and technology courses for different age groups, encouraging community engagement and support. Activities are designed to combat loneliness and provide emotional support to diverse demographics. The knitting club illustrates how shared interests can foster friendships and a sense of belonging. Educational programs, like the I-pad course for the elderly, empower participants with new skills and technology. The library adapts to the changing needs of the community despite financial challenges, showcasing its enduring role as a space for encounters and empowerment, particularly during the COVID-19 pandemic.

2.5 A place for all

Hillenbrand, C. (2005). *A Place for All: Social Capital at the Mount Barker Community Library, South Australia*. *Australasian Public Libraries and Information Services*, 18(2), 41–58. <https://search.informit.org/doi/10.3316/ielapa.005142107280428>

The Mount Barker Community Library, a joint-use facility shared by the community and Technical and Further Education (TAFE), is situated in one of South Australia's fastest-growing regional areas. A social capital audit report from 2004 highlights the findings of a study conducted on this library. The data reveals that for most users, the library's traditional functions such as borrowing books, accessing information, reading, and using computers and the Internet are viewed as the primary benefits of the service. Many respondents appreciated the fact that the library services are free, offering access to materials they might otherwise be unable to afford, and emphasize the library's accessibility and inclusivity. Additionally, numerous respondents expressed the value of the library as a peaceful retreat from a busy world. Some mentioned the library's role in fostering companionship and the potential for forming friendships, while others described it as a community hub and a source of information and entertainment.

2.6 Bridging Cultural Divides

Lee, P. (2024). *Bridging Cultural Divides: The role of public libraries in Taiwan in enhancing cultural capital and promoting social inclusion*. *Public Library Quarterly*, 1–28. <https://doi.org/10.1080/01616846.2024.2407683>

The Bridging Cultural Divides paper explores the role of the National Taiwan Library (NTL) in enhancing cultural capital and community integration through various educational workshops, accessible resources, and diverse programs. NTL promotes social inclusion by bridging cultural divides through collaborative initiatives and events that engage various community demographics. By fostering cultural competencies and engaging with local communities, NTL promotes cultural diversity and empowers individuals to actively participate in society. Collaborative efforts with educational institutions and cultural organizations further strengthen these initiatives, facilitating lifelong learning and cultural enrichment. NTL's strategic alliances, such as partnerships with the Hondao Senior Citizens' Welfare Foundation and the New Taipei City Social Affairs Bureau, have led to inclusive events that bridge cultural divides.



(Image: Melton Library, n.d.)



(Image: Melton Library, n.d.)



(Image: Melton Library, n.d.)

3. FINDINGS AND CONCLUSION

Public libraries serve a critical role not just as providers of information but as key hubs of community infrastructure. They promote social inclusion, foster community engagement, and address important social challenges like loneliness and cultural divides. Through strategic partnerships, diverse programming, and inclusive events, libraries enable communities to engage with a wide range of people, enhancing both social capital and lifelong learning. In rapidly growing areas like the City of Melton, stronger and more consistent funding for public libraries is essential to ensure the sustainable planning and delivery of infrastructure.

Public libraries should form partnerships with educational institutions, local businesses, and cultural organisations to expand their offerings and reach. Planning for new suburbs must also incorporate libraries as core social infrastructure, recognising their vital role in fostering community resilience, civic engagement, and cultural understanding.

Additionally, public libraries can help address pressing issues like loneliness and social isolation. Programs such as anti-loneliness lunches, skill-sharing clubs, and technology courses should be expanded, particularly for vulnerable populations like the elderly and immigrant communities.

To secure continued government support, libraries must demonstrate their community impact. Tracking metrics such as library usage, participation in community events, and contributions to lifelong learning will help highlight their essential role in building cohesive, resilient communities.

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